

Who are digital natives? The Privacy Authority responds

Guido Scorza, member of the Authority for the protection of personal data: "In reality, they do not exist; it is just a negative way of saying it."

Interview with Guido Scorza, Member of the Authority for the protection of personal data

(By Carlotta Di Santo, Dire, May 4, 2024)

"Digital natives do not exist; it is a way of saying that has harmed the management and governance of children's issues in the digital universe and has persuaded adults that there is no need to act like adults. Furthermore, it has convinced children even more that they know more than adults in the digital dimension and that, therefore, it is not necessary to turn to them." This is how Guido Scorza, a member of the Authority for the protection of personal data, responded during a video interview given to Dire on the occasion of the event 'The dignity of children in the digital world,' organized in Rome by the S.O.S. Telefono Azzurro Foundation in collaboration with the Italian Embassy to the Holy See and the Child Foundation in view of the National Day for the fight against pedophilia and child pornography.

"DO NOT CONFUSE DIGITAL NATIVES WITH DIGITAL SKILLS"

In reality, Scorza explained, one should not confuse being a 'digital native' with having digital skills, such as 'scrolling' or swiping on the screen of a smartphone or tablet as children do. This type of skill, as demonstrated by hundreds of thousands of videos on all platforms, is also possessed by monkeys and is acquired simply through habit and also because those platforms are scientifically designed to be foolproof for monkeys or children, who do exactly the same thing." It is, instead, "completely" different, Scorza continued, to define oneself as a 'digital native' in the sense of "knowing what happens behind that screen, how the internet works, why one content is proposed to us and another is not, or what interfaces are capable of generating addiction in the youngest. This, children do not know and cannot imagine."

"IT IS THE PARENTS' DUTY TO EXPLAIN WHAT HAPPENS BEHIND THE SCREEN"

It is therefore "certainly" the duty of parents, teachers, and institutions "to explain to the youngest what happens behind that screen, just as we teach them to cross the street. No one is born a 'digital native'; fortunately, people are not 'amphibians'; they know how to live in the physical dimension and only acquire culture, education, and the ability to stay afloat in the digital dimension through experience." During his speech, Scorza shared that he is the father of two daughters and that he himself is frightened by the dangers, sometimes even crimes, that can lurk online.

WHAT TOOLS DO PARENTS HAVE TO PROTECT THEIR CHILDREN?

"First of all, those same tools that understandably scare us," Scorza responded to Dire, "also offer adults the possibility, I am referring for example to parental control tools, to act like adults, that is, to be parents in the digital dimension, to set a maximum time limit for the use of different services, to establish reasonable boundaries to be respected within the minor's freedom to move in the digital dimension." And finally, there is the most important tool of all: "The parent can always remind the youngest that if somewhere it is written that that social platform is reserved, as it normally is for those who are at least 13 years old, they simply have to wait; no one dies. They will enjoy that experience more," concluded lawyer Scorza, "when they have all the necessary skills to enjoy it."